It is untenable to suggest that there can be a return to ‘business as usual’ for the larger relationship when the situation in the border areas is far from normal. Looking beyond, when a neighbour prepares, trains and exhorts, it is wise to focus on the capability rather than the professed intent, especially in a culture where public rhetoric is taken seriously. At the minimum, therefore, whatever engagement is feasible has to be undertaken with eyes extremely wide open.

In that context, the Indian side has to draw lessons even from the near past when it comes to handling China. To begin with, the public characterization of our ties is important. By describing it as a ‘strategic partnership’ in 2005, there was conceptual confusion about its real nature. Clearly, this description sat ill with unresolved boundary differences, growing transgressions and competitive neighbourhood activities. In fact, what it led to was the very complacency that made India underestimate the implications of Chinese-built ports in Hambantota and Gwadar.

Similarly, ritualistic reaffirmations of territorial integrity could not continue in a one-sided way. A balance has therefore been introduced. The neglect of the border infrastructure also spoke of a casual attitude towards the boundary dispute till 2014. Even more concerning was the underplaying of Sino-Pakistani cooperation in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK), until the current Indian government took a firm stand in 2017 on the BRI. Despite that, there are some from the old order who still advocate softening our stance.

On the economic side, it would appear astounding to many now that an FTA with China could even be contemplated. In such an atmosphere, informed scrutiny of activities within our country was not easy. The collapse of the Quad in 2007 in face of China’s objections sent its own message, making its revival a decade later that much harder. The very term ‘Chindia’ that was in vogue a decade earlier, with all its Nehruvian connotations, underlines why the loss of strategic clarity can be so damaging.

Given how severely developments since 2020 have eroded confidence and trust, it is obvious that stabilizing ties is the first order of the day. How to embark on that endeavour is best captured by certain propositions that reflect both experience and expectations. To begin with, agreements already reached, such as those of 1993 and 1996, must be adhered to in their